

Owls

Order Strigiformes

Barn owl

Tyto alba

- ↔ 12–18 in (30–46 cm)
- 📍 North, Central, and South America, Europe, Asia, Africa, Australia
- ⊗ Common

The most widespread of all owls, the barn owl has a white, heart-shaped face with black eyes and typically buff upperparts mottled with gray. It usually hunts by night, flying low over the ground in search of small prey such as voles, locating them mainly by sound. Barn owls often nest in barns and other buildings, but may also use holes in trees.

Spectacled owl

Pulsatrix perspicillata

- ↔ 17–21 in (43–53 cm)
- 📍 S. Mexico to C. South America
- ⊗ Common

Deep chocolate brown above and creamy white below, with a dark head and pale “spectacles” around its big yellow eyes, this forest bird has unusually striking plumage for an owl. The pattern helps to conceal it from enemies as it roosts by day on treetops. At night, it hunts from a perch, ambushing birds sleeping on trees and swooping down to the forest floor.

Great horned owl

Bubo virginianus

- ↔ 20–24 in (50–60 cm)
- 📍 North, Central, and South America
- ⊗ Common

The largest of all American owls, the great horned owl occurs in a variety of habitats ranging from rocky deserts to the cold northern conifer forests. It has a similarly wide range of prey, taking anything from beetles to jackrabbits. It hunts

at night, usually from a perch, seizing and killing its victims with its strong talons. Large prey are ripped apart, while smaller ones are swallowed whole.

Other species

- **Burrowing owl**
Athene cunicularia » p121
- **Great gray owl**
Strix nebulosa » p58
- **Snowy owl**
Nyctea scandiaca » p33

long, feathery, hornlike
ear tufts



Nightjars and frogmouths

Order Caprimulgiformes

European nightjar

Caprimulgus europaeus

- ↔ 10–11 in (25–28 cm)
- 📍 Europe, W. to E. Asia, NW., W., and SE. Africa
- ⊗ Common

Rarely seen because of its excellent camouflage, this nocturnal summer visitor to Europe reveals

its presence after nightfall with a churring song. It hunts for airborne insects such as moths, scooping them up in its gaping mouth as it flies on long, pointed wings. Males display in the air, clapping their wings together and gliding to show off the white spots on their wingtips and tail feathers.



Tawny frogmouth

Podargus strigoides

- ↔ 14–21 in (36–53 cm)
- 📍 S. New Guinea, Australia (including Tasmania)
- ⊗ Common

Related to nightjars, the tawny frogmouth has a similar nocturnal hunting habit. Instead of patrolling the air, however, it hunts from a perch, gliding down to catch prey on the ground. Its large mouth lets it swallow animals as big as mice and even snakes. By day, it sits still on a tree, where its cryptic, mottled plumage matches the bark and makes it all but invisible.



Hummingbirds and swifts

Order Apodiformes

Ruby-throated hummingbird

Archilochus colubris

- ↔ 4 in (10 cm)
- 📍 S. Canada, C. and E. US, Mexico to S. Central America
- ⊗ Common

In many ways a typical small hummingbird, with a diet of nectar, sweet tree sap, and a

few small insects, this species is remarkable for the long migrations between Central America and its breeding grounds, which may lie as far north as Canada. For some birds, this involves crossing the Gulf of Mexico, in a nonstop flight of some 530 miles (850 km) on tiny, whirring wings. Both sexes are green above and mainly grayish white below, but only the male has a ruby-red throat.